

To prepare myself for the journey from my home in Canberra, Australia, I visited the National Library's vast collection of maps. But I could not find Steinkirche, even in old German records of Silesia. The Polish-German Gazetteer, which has a remarkable list of old German place-names in relation to their Polish replacements, and vice versa, gave the names for many places, including Märzdorf where my mother had worked as a young woman, on an estate near the Oder River. But there was nothing for Steinkirche. The people assembling the directory must have thought it simply the description of a stone church, as the name suggests, rather than the actual name for the place where the church stood.

Obviously it was not an important village. No one in our extended family could give me the Polish names for rural Steinkirche or of Neumarkt Platz in the Silesian metropolis. Had Steinkirche been north, east, west or south of Breslau? In my mind's eye I assumed it to be east—towards Posen—mistakenly, so I was to discover. In answer to one of my many questions, I recalled that my mother had once told me that it had taken her about an hour by train to travel to the school she attended briefly in Breslau. It was an important clue.

I then rang my cousin, Peter Erlanger, but neither he nor his older sister could help me. Peter advised me to try to find Steinkirche using my computer's Internet search engine. It was enlightened advice, and was to provide me with a key clue. The website yielded a huge list of entries, mostly concerning stone churches in present-day Germany. But there was also a reference to a 1928 visit by a church official inspecting a number of communities overseen by the Lutheran Church at Strehlen. I had often heard my mother and her sister refer to acquaintances in Strehlen.

The article about Steinkirche described it as having a 1264 Polish Catholic foundation, on a site where pagan sacrifices had taken place. This seemed to have the ring of truth. The description offered a brief history of the church and gave illustrations of it in various stages of alteration. By the seventeenth century, the place had become Lutheran and in the following 200 years the community's religious confidence expressed itself architecturally, through continual improvements. A church tower with baroque spire was raised and the interior refurbished with an upper-storey balcony with pews on three sides.